Plinko: development plan

Build Queue 243 to 246, 2026-10-20. Modeled on Baamboozle's Plink-oh, built our way: questions first, iPad first, read aloud, no em dashes.

> **Her words:** "1 - the design of our plink needs to be modeled after Baamboozles Plink-oh game. 2, questions should alwyas pop up in our native regular way, drop zones selected after. power ups should show on the right side, score board on the left. 3- multiplayer game." "I want to make this game with customizable theme/designs ... a pdf file (or image files) that can be downloaded, uploaded to canva, and added ... they can then be selected at the main menu screen after i upload the theme as a teacher."

Where it is today

- Plinko Drop: one player. The four answers label four chutes at the top; dropping down the right chute sends the ball through the pegs into a ticket slot (2, 5, 1, 3, 10, 3, 1, 5, 2). Tickets buy carnival plushies at the Prize Counter; $1 Class Cash per right answer.
- Start card with a "Drops this game" slider (5 to 20).
- What changes: the answer is no longer the drop chute. The question comes first, in the normal question pop-up, and only a right answer earns a drop.

The new game, screen by screen

1. Main menu (Plink-oh setup screen)

- Big themed title (the theme's title image), three big sliders: **Players** (1 to 4), **Questions** (how many drops in the whole game, shown as "8 each"), **Game time** (off, 3, 5, 10 minutes).
- **Theme picker:** a row of theme covers (Carnival, Winter, Dogs, and every theme she uploads). The picked theme dresses every screen.
- Next goes to Players. Same settings card rules as every game (her assignment can lock them).

2. Players

- One big ball per player, each in its theme ball picture, with a name button: the student's own name for player 1, then classmates typed or picked, or a Neighbor (Phase 2). Random shuffles who goes first.

3. A turn

- **Question first:** the native question pop-up (the same one every game uses: read aloud, the 3-second read first pause, toolbox, one try).

- **Right answer:** the drop board opens. The ball slides along the top; the student taps a drop zone (or drags the ball and lets go). Plink-oh style board: tall, about 6 columns of pegs, a few bonus pegs, four big score buckets at the bottom (10, 30, 20, 40, order shuffled every round).
- **Wrong answer:** the right answer shows and the turn passes (Skip, like Plink-oh). No drop, no points.
- **Left side: scoreboard.** Every player's ball, name and score, a crown on the leader, "Round 2 of 8" at the bottom.
- **Right side: power-ups.** A card shows the power-up this turn earned (about one in three right answers), with Use and Save buttons.

4. Power-ups (first set)

Power-up	What it does
Double	This drop's bucket counts twice.
Big Ball	A bigger ball that bounces less, easier to aim.
Magnet	Pulls the ball toward the 40 bucket.
Second Drop	Drop a second ball.
Swap	Trade scores with the leader (multiplayer only, once a game).
Freeze	The next player's buckets are all 10 (multiplayer only).

Bonus pegs on the board (like Plink-oh's stars): touching one adds 5 points. Nothing is ever taken away from a student for a wrong answer.

5. End

- Podium with every player's ball and score, confetti, the winner read aloud. Class Cash goes to the logged-in student ($1 per right answer, as today). Tickets and the Prize Counter stay.

Phases

Phase	What ships
1 (Build Queue 244)	New layout (scoreboard left, board middle, power-ups right), question pop-up first then pick the drop zone, Plink-oh board with 4 buckets and bonus pegs, the 6 power-ups, the setup screen with sliders, the built-in Carnival theme. One player.
2 (245)	Multiplayer on one iPad: 2 to 4 players or teams take turns, each with their own ball and score; "Pass the iPad to Ava" screen between turns; a Neighbor can be a player (it answers on its own, using its personality); the game joins the 2+ player list so Neighbors can be invited.
3 (246)	Custom themes: the Canva theme kit, a Theme manager for the teacher (upload pieces, preview, release), theme picker on the menu, Winter and Dogs starter themes.

	Student-made themes come through the teacher (she uploads them after looking).
Later	Online multiplayer across iPads with a 4-digit join code (like the Gus live share), seasonal themes that switch on by date, a theme contest.

Custom themes: how it works (updated with her rules, Build Queue 251)

What a theme can change

Part	What you design
Background	Fully your design.
Board and pegs	Colors only: border, background, pegs. Peg placement never changes.
Balls	Your ball designs: at least 5 (one per player), up to 10.
Buckets	Colors only (up to 8).
Title	The game name in your lettering, text only (see-through background).
Side panels	Background design, plus the theme font.
Power-ups	Button and background colors.
Palette and font	Primary (main color), secondary (buttons), text color; the font is picked from a list when uploading.

Making it (one Canva project)

- Download **plinko-theme-template.pdf**: 5 pages, all the same size, so it opens in Canva as one project (Create a design, Import file).
- Everything solid black is off limits; white words on the black say what each white space is for. There are no words inside the white spaces.
- Page 1 Background (white box). Page 2 Balls (10 white circles, 1 to 5 needed). Page 3 Title (letters only; the white around them turns see-through). Page 4 Side panel. Page 5 Colors (fill each white square with one solid color: primary, secondary, text, board border, board background, pegs, power-up background, power-up buttons, buckets 1 to 8).
- Download the whole project as one PDF (Share, Download, PDF Standard) and upload that one file.

Adding it (teacher)

- Teacher → Plinko themes → Upload: pick the PDF, name the theme, choose the font. The app cuts out every piece, reads the colors and shows the real board as a preview.

- New themes start hidden; only **Approve** puts a theme on the students' theme picker. Until then everyone plays the plain default look. Students who design a theme hand her the PDF.

Claudia's checks (high support learners)

- Read first: questions come before any aiming, so a student cannot win by tapping fast. The 3-second pause applies.
- Aiming is easy for every motor level: tap a drop zone (no precise drag needed), Big Ball helps.
- Turn taking is clear: whose turn it is shows in the player's ball color and is read aloud.
- Themes must keep the ball and buckets easy to see: the preview warns when the board is too busy or text is hard to read.
- iPad first: big buttons, both orientations (in portrait the scoreboard and power-ups sit above and below the board).

Questions for her

- Should a wrong answer pass the turn (Plink-oh) or give one more try for half points?
- Keep tickets and the Prize Counter, or only points and Class Cash?
- Can students upload their own themes straight from their account, or always through her? (Plan: through her.)